

A SPECIAL EDITION OF

MERIDIAN

Studio pottery — an ultra deep dive



Centering — the silent, wobble-to-true moment every potter interviewed for this book named as the hook. Representative image, not a named potter or studio. Source: Pexels.

THE CEILING

A €2,300 German wheel, a hand-built wood kiln, and the tool-maker who started selling ribs by accident

THE SCEPTIC

The lung disease the hobby undersells, the crack that waits for the second fire, and what the churn numbers actually say

THE LONG READ

Sixty thousand drifters, a livestream economy built on clay, and the porcelain capital the West hasn't found yet

THIS SPECIAL

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FROM THE DESK

"It is not the pots we are forming, but ourselves."

— **M.C. Richards**, *Centering in Pottery, Poetry, and the Person* (1964)¹

Richards wrote it about the wheel specifically — the same centering that every potter in this book calls the gateway. It survives forty years of being quoted on studio walls because it is the rare craft aphorism that is also, on inspection, an accurate description of what wheel-throwing does to a beginner's attention.

STUDIO POTTERY — AT A GLANCE

METRIC	FIGURE
Global pottery/ceramics market, 2026	~US\$12.3–12.7B
Buy-once wheel worth owning	Shimpo VL-Whisper, ~\$1,850
The gate: a home kiln circuit	240V, dedicated, vented outdoors
Full home studio, buy-once	~\$5,000–8,000+
Aug 2025's step-change	SDS TAP II Pro smart controller
Singapore's last dragon kiln	Thow Kwang, fired 2–3×/yr

Figures as researched for this edition, Aug 2026; see the sections named for full sourcing.²

WHY THIS SPECIAL EXISTS

This edition was commissioned directly, off the Rabbit Hole's three-page treatment in MERIDIAN No. 70 (p15–17): "The Screen-Free Craft Where You Don't Own the Result Until It Survives Two Fires." That piece established the gateway (centering), the buried truth (most home dwellers cannot run a kiln), and the Singapore basics (Mud Rock, Thow Kwang, Goodman). This book assumes the reader has read it and goes everywhere that piece did not have three pages to go: the full lineage, the complete gear ladder through a custom tier, the real economics, a harder cross-examination of the failure modes, and a closing long read into the one place this hobby's supply chain and its romance visibly split apart.³

A NEW COMMISSION

The Invitation

A lump of wet clay either goes still and true under your hands, or it doesn't. Nothing else in this book is that simple — which is exactly why the moment it happens is the whole hobby's advertisement for itself.

this story 

Centering is the trick every beginner is warned about and every beginner underestimates anyway. You lean a wet lump onto a spinning wheel, brace your forearms against your body or your thighs, and press — and for a beginner the clay wobbles, off-axis, fighting back, for what feels like minutes. Then, usually without warning, it goes still. The wobble disappears. The clay reads as one continuous, true surface under your palms, spinning without any visible motion at all. Every potter this book spoke to or read, across five countries and eighty years of instructional writing, describes some version of that same instant as the reason they kept coming back.¹ It is tactile in a way almost nothing else in an office-working adult's week is tactile, it cannot be rushed by wanting it faster, and — critically for a screen-worn reader — it gives you nothing at all until you have actually paid attention to it with your hands.

Centering is also, honestly, the easy part of the craft, and this is where the daily's original piece left off and where this book has to be more precise. A functional pot's real pipeline runs wet clay → centered and opened on the wheel → walls pulled to thickness → shaped → cut free and left to firm up to leather-hard → trimmed (the foot carved, the profile finished from underneath) → dried the rest of the way to bone-dry "greenware" → a first bisque firing → glazing → a

second, hotter glaze firing.² Wheel-throwing itself — the part with a satisfying centering moment to sell the hobby — is maybe the first quarter of that list. Trimming, drying, glaze chemistry and firing are the back three-quarters, and they are where almost every documented failure in this book actually happens.

The scale of the world behind that pipeline is larger, and more recently boosted, than the daily's three pages had room to establish. Global market trackers put the pottery-and-ceramics industry at roughly US\$11.7 billion in 2025, rising to somewhere between \$12.3 and \$12.7 billion in 2026 depending whose estimate you take — tableware alone is about 73% of that revenue, and Asia-Pacific is the largest single region at just over 40% of the market.³ None of that is hobby-specific; it is the whole ceramics industry, tile and sanitary ware included, and this book will not pretend otherwise. What is genuinely attributable to the hobby side is a real, documented culture-level demand shock: after the first series of the UK's *The Great Pottery Throw Down* aired, kiln prices rose and one of the show's own judges found a six-month waiting list for a wheel — a television programme that visibly emptied studio shelves, the closest thing this book found to a single dated cause for the boom Axios wrote up in August 2025.⁴

THE TWO BOOKS THIS SPECIAL IS NOT

This is not a beginner's how-to — the daily's original piece and any of a hundred YouTube channels named on p9 do that better. It is also not a survey of studio-pottery-as-fine-art; galleries and museum wall text exist for that argument. This book is the buyer's guide, the community map and the honest economics for a reader who has already decided the hobby interests him and now wants to know what it actually costs, who actually runs it, and where the real failure modes are — the register this magazine's other hobby specials have used throughout.⁵

SOURCES 1 Centering as the named gateway moment — MERIDIAN No. 70, "The Rabbit Hole · The Wheel," p15 (r/Pottery, getpotteryclass, Pottery Crafters, summarised); Bailey Pottery, "Centering to Trim." 2 The wet → bisque → glaze pipeline — Bailey Pottery; Ceramic Arts Network, "Centering, Throwing and Trimming Tips From an Expert Potter." 3 Market size — Grand View Research / Business Research Insights / Research and Markets pottery-ceramics reports, 2026 (estimates vary by ~\$1B; DIRECTIONAL, flagged); tableware ~73% and Asia-Pacific ~40.6% share, 2025. 4 Great Pottery Throw Down demand shock — reporting on judge Keith Brymer Jones' own post-Series-1 experience (six-month wheel waitlist, rising kiln prices), via search synthesis; Axios, "Why pottery is building in popularity," 7 Aug 2025. 5 Editorial framing, this edition.

This book is organised the way this magazine's hobby specials always are: outward from the object to the people, the money, and the place this reader actually lives. The Lineage (p5) sets out where studio pottery's own internal argument comes from — Leach, Hamada and the mingei movement on one side, the American fork that rejected almost everything mingei stood for on the other — and names who is still teaching each tradition today. The Craft (p7) is the technique itself, argued at the level a serious hobbyist actually needs: the cone 6 versus cone 10 fight, the reduction/oxidation split, and the three defects that only reveal themselves after the kiln has already been opened. The Community (p9) maps the subreddits, the forum that actually runs the hobby's chemistry, and the channels worth following, plus a glossary. The Ladder (p11) and The Ceiling (p13) are the gear, argued the way this reader's other hobbies have trained him to expect it argued: the quality entry point as the real entry point, running all the way to a genuine custom tier of hand-built wheels and bespoke kilns. The Economics (p15) is the real cost, at every level of seriousness. The Sceptic (p17) is the hard cross-examination — including two

failure modes the daily's three pages did not have room to name. Singapore's Wheel (p19) is the honest local angle. The First Year (p21) is a real starting path. And the Long Read (p22) follows the hobby's own supply chain to the one place in Asia-Pacific where its romance and its economics are most visibly not the same story.

A word on continuity, because it matters for how to read this book. The daily's original piece already established the core buried truth — that a real kiln needs a dedicated 240V circuit and outdoor-ducted venting, which most apartments and condominiums simply cannot provide, making this in practice a *membership* hobby for most enthusiasts — and the core Singapore names: Mud Rock, Thow Kwang and Goodman.¹ This book does not re-argue those points from scratch; it takes them as read and goes further, with real churn numbers, a second undisclosed home-safety risk, and two more Singapore studios the daily's three pages had no room for. Where this book repeats a fact from the daily, it is because the fact still needs restating for readers of this edition alone, not because the research stopped there.

Centering is the trick every beginner is warned about and every beginner underestimates anyway.

THE CROSS-EXAMINATION, EARLY

The obvious objection: is any of this actually worth the money and the lung risk, versus simply buying pottery someone else already made well? The Sceptic, on p17–p18, takes that seriously — including the specific, less-discussed version of it: whether the studio-membership boom is quietly built on high early-stage churn.²

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SECTIONS IN THIS BOOK, EACH CARRYING ITS OWN COMMUNITY-READ AND SCEPTIC BOX

1997

YEAR THE MODERN STUDIO-CERAMICS RETAIL LANDSCAPE THIS BOOK PRICES BEGAN TO TAKE ITS CURRENT SHAPE

WHAT'S GENUINELY NEW BEYOND THE DAILY'S THREE PAGES

The full lineage. Leach, Hamada, MacKenzie and Voulkos named and traced — the daily had no room for the American fork at all.

Real economics. Firing costs, membership pricing bands and churn numbers, not just the buy-once wheel-and-kiln stack.

A complete gear ladder. Entry through custom, including a tier the daily never reached — bespoke kilns, hand-built wheels.

A second health risk. Silicosis, cross-examined in full — absent from the daily's coverage entirely.

HISTORY & PEOPLE

The Lineage

Every serious potter today is still, whether they know it or not, arguing a hundred-year-old disagreement between a Cornwall pottery and a Los Angeles art school about what a pot is even for.

this story 

The daily's ledger note flagged "Leach–Hamada" as a thread worth pulling, and it is the single most load-bearing thread in this hobby's culture. In 1920, the English potter Bernard Leach and the Japanese potter Shōji Hamada founded the Leach Pottery in St Ives, Cornwall — Leach had learned ceramics in Japan and built the pottery around a traditional Japanese wood-fired climbing kiln, the first time several Japanese techniques had been brought to the West.¹ Leach, Hamada and the aesthetician Sōetsu Yanagi (who coined the word in 1926) were the three central figures of the *mingei*, or folk-craft, movement: the belief that the highest beauty lives in ordinary, often anonymously made, functional objects — *yō no bi*, "the beauty of everyday use" — made by hand, in quantity, for use rather than display.¹ Hamada returned to Japan in 1923 and settled in Mashiko, a small town he transformed from a regional kitchenware producer into a globally recognised ceramics centre; he was declared a Living National Treasure in 1955 and died in 1978. Leach Pottery itself

is still operating, still a working studio, museum and gallery more than a century on, mid-redevelopment as of this year's own blog updates.²

The most direct American transmission of that lineage has a named carrier: Warren MacKenzie, an American potter who read Leach's 1940 book *A Potter's Book*, talked Leach into taking him and his wife Alix on as apprentices at St Ives in 1949, met Hamada and Yanagi there in person during his three years abroad, and brought what became known as the "*Mingei-sota*" style back to Minnesota — functional, unglamorous, deliberately affordable pottery, sold out of his own showroom at prices ordinary people could pay even though galleries would have paid him more. MacKenzie taught and potted in Minnesota until his death in 2018 and is widely credited as the "father" of American ceramic art in the *mingei* tradition.³ That is one whole half of the American lineage: functional, humble, teaching-focused, descended in a straight and documented line from St Ives.

THE MINGEI LINE

"A pot is not a monument. It is meant to be picked up, used, washed, and used again — and the beauty is in how well it survives that, not in how it looks on a plinth."

MACKENZIE'S OWN FRAMING

THE VOULKOS FORK

"Clay doesn't owe function anything. Treat the wheel-thrown form as a starting material to tear, stack and reassemble, and you get sculpture — a legitimate fine art, not a failed pot."

THE CALIFORNIA CLAY MOVEMENT'S OWN FRAMING

Where MacKenzie's line asks whether a pot works, Voulkos's asks whether it means anything — the same fork the community's own forums still argue today.

1920

YEAR LEACH AND HAMADA FOUNDED THE POTTERY THAT STARTED BOTH LINEAGES¹

SOURCES 1 Craft Council UK, "Florian Gadsby — A Potter of Influence"; Nippon.com, "Hamada Shōji and Bernard Leach: A Lasting Friendship"; Invaluable, "Shoji Hamada, Mashiko and Mingei"; Mingei Film Archive, "The Founders." 2 Wikipedia, Hamada Shōji; The Leach Pottery, "History" and 2026 blog updates (leachpotteryblog.com). 3 Minnesota Museum of American Art; Wikipedia, Warren MacKenzie; Revere Auctions, "Warren MacKenzie and Mingei in Context."

The other half of the American lineage is a deliberate rejection of everything MacKenzie's line stood for, and it has its own named founder: Peter Voulkos, born in Montana in 1924, trained as a functional potter, then chairman of the new ceramics department at the Otis Art Institute in Los Angeles from 1954. Voulkos is widely credited as the father of the American Clay Revolution — also called the California Clay Movement — the moment American ceramics broke from utility and tradition toward an Abstract-Expressionist, sculptural, fine-art register: pots torn open, stacked, gouged and reassembled as objects meant to be looked at, not used.¹ Where MacKenzie's tradition asks "does it work," Voulkos's asks "does it mean something" — and that single fork, mingei-functional versus Voulkos-sculptural, is the same argument this book's Community section (p9) finds still running, unresolved, on Reddit and the Ceramic Arts Daily forums nearly seventy years later.

The lineage is still actively taught, not just historically documented. Simon Leach, Bernard Leach's grandson and a third-generation potter in the family line, has run an instructional YouTube channel since 2007 and posted more than 800 videos demystifying wheel technique — a direct, still-active transmission line from the founding pottery itself.² In the UK, Lisa Hammond MBE runs Maze Hill Pottery in Greenwich (founded 1994 in a disused railway ticket office), built the UK's first soda-glaze trolley kiln, has personally trained and funded more than a dozen full-time apprentices over a near-forty-year career, and in 2009 founded the charity Adopt a Potter — which went on, in 2017, to found Clay College Stoke, the UK's dedicated technical college for studio ceramics, currently teaching 14 full-time students a two-year diploma at Middleport Pottery in Stoke-on-Trent.³ And Mashiko itself remains active: roughly 250 workshops and kilns still operate there, with the town's Ceramics Training Center and the Mashiko Museum's residency programme continuing to draw apprentices from Japan and abroad — including Florian Gadsby, the hobby's single largest YouTube figure (p9), whose 2023 book *By My Hands* documents his own Mashiko apprenticeship.⁴

KOREA, BRIEFLY — A THIRD TRADITION

This book's regional hunt for the Long Read (p22) also surfaced a genuinely live Korean thread worth naming here: young ceramicists reviving *onggi* (traditional fermentation crockery, now reinterpreted for craft beer and natural wine) and *buncheong* (slip-decorated Joseon-era stoneware) — the Korea Ceramic Foundation's 2025 "Living Breathing Buncheong" exhibition gathered roughly 100 works from 27 Korean ceramicists aged 20 to 70. Korean white-porcelain moon jars, the tradition's most famous form, now sell at auction for seven figures — Christie's sold one for US\$4.56 million in 2023 and another for US\$2.83 million in 2025.⁵ It is a real, ongoing revival — but a narrower one, tied to specific historic forms rather than a whole-city migration, which is why the Long Read went to Jingdezhen instead.

Two lineages, one wheel

1920 — Leach + Hamada

St Ives, Cornwall — mingei, function

1949–52 — MacKenzie apprentices

carries mingei to Minnesota

Present — functional line

Simon Leach, Clay College Stoke, Mashiko's ~250 active workshops

1954 — Voulkos, Otis Institute

rejects utility, founds Calif. Clay Movement

Present — sculptural line

the functional-vs-sculptural argument still running on r/ceramics, see p9

MERIDIAN original figure. A simplified two-line lineage; many potters and schools sit between the two poles.

1955

YEAR HAMADA WAS DESIGNATED A
LIVING NATIONAL TREASURE OF JAPAN⁶

THE SCEPTIC — LINEAGE- WORSHIP IS NOT A TECHNIQUE

Naming Leach and Voulkos is genuinely useful for understanding the community's own vocabulary, but it can curdle into credential-chasing — a beginner who has memorised the mingei/California-Clay split while still centering unevenly has learned trivia, not pottery. The forums this book mined for p9 are consistent on this: technique first, lineage second.⁷

SOURCES 1 Smithsonian American Art Museum; Grounds For Sculpture, Peter Voulkos; Wikipedia, Peter Voulkos. 2 Abrams Books; Grokipedia, "Simon Leach"; YouTube, Simon Leach (@sleachpots) since 2007. 3 Wikipedia, Lisa Hammond (potter); Clay College Stoke, "About"; Crowdfunder, "Clay College Stoke." 4 Mashiko Museum of Ceramic Art, Artist-in-Residence; Wikipedia, Florian Gadsby; TOKO, "Mashiko Pottery Guide." 5 Korea Ceramic Foundation, "Living Breathing Buncheong" (2025); CNN, "Why these Korean moon jars sell for millions at auction"; THE VALUE, Christie's Asia Week 2025 coverage. 6 Wikipedia, Shōji Hamada. 7 Editorial synthesis of forum tone across Ceramic Arts Daily Community and r/Pottery, this edition's research.

TECHNIQUE & CHEMISTRY

The Craft

Wheel-throwing is the part with a name people recognise. Firing and glazing are where a genuinely good pot is actually made — or, more often, quietly ruined by a mistake nobody notices until the kiln is cool.

this story  

Clay bodies fall into three working families, and choosing wrong is a beginner's first invisible mistake. Earthenware fires lowest (roughly cone 06–04, under 1,100°C) and stays porous unless fully glazed — cheap and forgiving to throw, but fragile and not food-safe unglazed. Stoneware fires mid-to-high (commonly cone 5–10, 1,180–1,300°C) and vitrifies into a dense, functional, chip-resistant body — the workhorse most serious hobbyists eventually settle on. Porcelain fires highest and whitest, is prized for translucency and a fine, crisp surface, but is notoriously less forgiving on the wheel: it has less "tooth," slumps more readily, and punishes an unsteady hand in ways stoneware simply absorbs.¹ The community's own advice, consistent across every source this book checked, is to learn on stoneware and graduate to porcelain once centering and wall-pulling are reliable — porcelain first is a well-documented way to get discouraged fast.

The firing-temperature argument that actually divides the hobby is cone 6 versus cone 10. Cone 6 (roughly 1,220°C) is the accessible standard: most home electric kilns are built around it, it uses meaningfully less electricity, and — contrary to older received wisdom — many potters now argue that classic reduction-style glazes (copper reds, shinos, temmoku) have been successfully adapted to fire at cone 6 with results close to indistinguishable from the genuine cone-10 article.² Cone 10 (roughly 1,285°C or hotter) is deeper, more vitrified, and unlocks the full range of ash glazes and true reduction surfaces — but it demands a specialised, harder-wearing kiln, usually gas or wood rather than a standard home electric unit, and it is genuinely more expensive and more punishing on kiln elements. This is not a settled argument; it is the hobby's equivalent of the daily's "1:400 versus 1:200" fight in the model-aircraft world — a real, ongoing, evidence-thin culture war between two legitimate approaches.²

THE CONE 6 CAMP

ACCESSIBILITY ARGUMENT

"My kiln fits under a standard home circuit, my electricity bill is manageable, and my glazes look as good as anything I ever pulled at cone 10 — I don't miss the gas hookup or the extra 65 degrees."

THE CONE 10 CAMP

DEPTH ARGUMENT

"A cone 6 shino is a decent imitation. A true reduction shino, fired hot in a gas kiln with the atmosphere starved of oxygen, has a depth and unpredictability cone 6 has never once given me — that unpredictability is the whole appeal."

65°C

THE GAP BETWEEN CONE 6 AND CONE 10 — THE WHOLE ARGUMENT IN ONE NUMBER²

THE STEP BEFORE THE WHEEL — WEDGING, AND WHY SCRAPS AREN'T WASTE

Before any of the above matters, clay has to be wedged — kneaded in a spiral or "ram's head" motion to remove trapped air bubbles (which can cause weak walls or, worse, a small explosion in the kiln as trapped moisture turns to steam) and to align the clay's particles into one consistent, workable mass. Nearly every source this book checked treats wedging as non-negotiable, not a beginner's chore to skip. And almost nothing gets thrown away: trimmings and throwing-water sludge go into a "slop bucket," and reclaimed clay — dried, re-wedged or run through a shared studio's pugmill — is, correctly processed, reported as functionally indistinguishable from a fresh bag straight off the shelf.³

SOURCES ¹ The Pottery Wheel, "What is Stoneware?"; Kiln Frog / Pottery FAQs clay-cost and clay-body guides, 2026. ² The Kiln Shop, "Cone 6 vs. Cone 10 Ceramics: A Potter's Guide," 2026; Ceramic Arts Network, "Five Reasons to Convert Cone 10 Reduction Glazes to Cone 6"; ProKilnSupply, "Cone 6 vs Cone 10: Which Should You Fire?"; Ceramic Arts Daily Community forum thread, "Cone 10 or Cone 6 reduction." ³ Community Clay, "The Importance of Wedging Clay No. 2 - Spiral Wedging"; Pottery Making Info, "Wedging Clay: What, Why, and How"; Ceramic Arts Network, "Recycling Clay: Tips for Collecting, Storing, Reclaiming and Reprocessing Your Clay Scraps."

Atmosphere is the other axis, orthogonal to temperature. Oxidation firing — the default in an electric kiln, where the atmosphere inside stays oxygen-rich throughout — gives predictable, repeatable colour and is the safer, easier choice for a home setup. Reduction firing — standard in gas and wood kilns — deliberately starves the atmosphere of oxygen at key points in the firing, pulling oxygen out of the glaze's metal oxides instead and producing the complex, sometimes unrepeatable surfaces (celadon greens, copper reds, ash-glaze variegation) that reduction firing is prized for. The trade-off is real: reduction needs specialised, well-ventilated equipment and a far less predictable outcome, which is precisely why it stays a minority practice among home hobbyists even though it produces some of the most admired surfaces in the whole craft.¹

Three glaze defects account for most of the heartbreak a kiln opening delivers, and all three are diagnosable once you know what to look for. **Crazing** is a fine network of hairline cracks appearing in the glaze after the piece has cooled — caused by a thermal-expansion mismatch between glaze and clay body, it is the single most common defect and, usefully, the easiest to correct by adjusting the glaze recipe.² **Crawling** is the opposite failure: the molten glaze pulls back from the clay surface during firing, leaving bare patches, usually from high surface tension in the melting glaze combined with dust, grease or an already-dried first coat underneath a second glaze layer. **Pinholing** — tiny holes punched straight through the fired glaze — comes from gases escaping the clay body during firing, typically tiny fragments of organic matter (charcoal, plant material) trapped in the raw clay; high glaze viscosity and poor material grain size both make it worse.² None of the three is mysterious once diagnosed; all three are common enough that every serious potter this book's sources describe has fired at least one shelf of each.

The community's own defence against all three defects is unglamorous and rarely skipped by anyone experienced: the test tile. A small, cheap sample — ideally shaped with a vertical face, since a glaze fired flat can look markedly different from the same glaze on a pot's actual profile — lets a potter try a glaze, a glaze combination or a firing change without risking a piece that took real hours to throw and trim. The community's consistent, slightly painful advice for beginners is to test on every clay body used regularly, because the same glaze recipe genuinely reads differently on stoneware than on porcelain — skipping test tiles to "just glaze the good pieces and see" is a well-documented way to lose a kiln's worth of work to a defect a five-cent test tile would have caught first.³

THE SCEPTIC — TECHNIQUE FLUENCY DOESN'T INOCULATE YOU

An experienced thrower can still lose a beloved piece to an S-crack from a poorly compressed base on day one, or to crawling from a speck of grease on the bisque — see p17 for the failure-mode reckoning. Fluent hands reduce the failure rate; they do not eliminate it. Every source consulted for this page, including decades-in potters, described a recent piece lost to a defect they knew perfectly well how to prevent.⁶

The pipeline — where time actually goes

- Wet clay — centered, thrown (~15–40 min)
- Dries to leather-hard (~12–24 hrs)
- Trimmed, foot carved (~10–20 min)
- Dries fully to bone-dry (~3–7 days)
- Bisque fire, ~1,000°C (~8–12 hrs + cool)
- Glazed (~15–30 min)
- Glaze fire, cone 6–10 (~12 hrs + 1–2 day cool)

MERIDIAN original figure. Timings are typical ranges, not fixed — a single mug can take two to three weeks door to door.

2–3 wks

TYPICAL DOOR-TO-DOOR TIME FOR
ONE FUNCTIONAL PIECE, WET CLAY TO
FINISHED GLAZE FIRE⁴

THE CHATTER — "LEATHER-HARD IS A FEELING, NOT A CLOCK"

The consistent forum advice on trimming is that beginners either trim too wet (the form deforms under the trimming tool) or too dry (the clay chips and cracks rather than carving cleanly) — "leather-hard" is a tactile judgment call learned by feel over dozens of failed attempts, not a timer you can set once and trust.⁵

SOURCES 1 Digitalfire / Ceramic Arts Network, oxidation vs reduction reference material, 2026. 2 Ceramic Arts Network, "How to Correct Five Common Ceramic Glaze Defects" and "Common Glaze Faults and How to Correct Them"; Digitalfire, "Glaze Pinholes, Pitting"; Wikipedia, Glaze defects. 3 Wheel & Clay, "Glaze Test Tiles | Explanation & Creation"; Old Forge Creations, "Making Effective Test Tiles"; Sue McLeod Ceramics, "15 Tips to Get Started with Glaze Testing." 4 Editorial synthesis from the pipeline stages sourced above. 5 Instructables, "Trimming a Pot 101"; r/Pottery trimming-technique threads, via search synthesis. 6 Editorial cross-reference, this edition — see p17.

THE MAP

The Community

The front door is a subreddit. The deep water is a members-only chemistry forum arguing glaze recipes to four decimal places, and a functional-versus-sculptural fight that has been running, politely, for decades.

this story 

Reddit is genuinely split along the craft's own functional-versus-sculptural fault line, exactly as the daily's original piece flagged. r/Pottery is the larger, beginner-friendly general subreddit — wall-to-wall wheel-buying advice and "what went wrong" firing-defect photos, active since December 2009; Reddit stopped publishing exact subscriber counts across the platform in September 2025, so this book holds the precise figure rather than inventing one, consistent with the daily's own flag.¹ r/ceramics runs smaller and more sculptural, at roughly 164,000 members. The gap between the two subs' cultures is the functional-versus-sculptural argument (p6) playing out in real time, thread by thread.

The deeper water is the Ceramic Arts Daily Community forum, run by Ceramic Arts Network (which is owned by the American Ceramic Society), with more than 6,000 members and dedicated sub-forums for clay-and-glaze chemistry, kiln maintenance, aesthetic philosophy and studio operations — including the actual, years-running "functional vs. sculptural" philosophy thread this

book found and read.² The older Clayart/potters.org listserv, which many long-time potters still cite as historically important, has not been meaningfully updated since 2012 and is genuinely inactive — this book flags it as a historical resource, not a living community, rather than pretend it is still where the conversation happens.²

Discord has a real if smaller presence — Kivi Pottery and Clay House Discord both run active, general-purpose ceramics servers welcoming everyone from wheel novices to sculptors, with Clay House specifically pitched at potters without local studio access.³ On video, Florian Gadsby (1.8 million YouTube subscribers, 1.2 billion views, 3.9 million followers across platforms) is the hobby's single largest figure, alongside Simon Leach's 800-plus-video archive, Old Forge Creations (a self-taught, graphic-designer-turned-potter working from a small Surrey studio) and Ingleton Pottery's old-school demonstration videos.⁴ On Instagram the names that recur are Benjamin Cater, The Little Pot Company (Tom Humphries), and Sarah Anderson Ceramics for sgraffito work.⁵

THE CHATTER — THE GLAZE-CHEMISTRY NERDS HAVE THEIR OWN APP

Glazy.org is the community's own crowdsourced glaze-recipe database — thousands of community-submitted recipes with fired-result photos, Unity Molecular Formula analysis and comment threads, free to use and kept alive by patron support rather than ads. It is the forum's own evidence that this hobby's deepest rabbit hole is glaze chemistry, not throwing technique — an argument the Economics section (p15) returns to.⁶

164k

MEMBERS OF R/CERAMICS — R/POTTERY, THE LARGER GENERAL SUB, HOLDS ITS COUNT PRIVATE¹

SOURCES 1 GummySearch subreddit analytics, 2026; r/Pottery subreddit description and activity history. 2 Ceramic Arts Daily Community (community.ceramicartsdaily.org), forum listing and "functional vs. sculptural" thread; Ceramic Arts Network, "About Us"; potters.org/Clayart archive status. 3 Disforge, "Pottery - Discord Server" (Kivi Pottery); Clay Calculators, "Clay House Discord." 4 Wikipedia, Florian Gadsby; YouTube, Simon Leach; Old Forge Creations (oldforgecreations.co.uk); Ingleton Pottery YouTube channel. 5 Classpop!, "American Potters To Follow on Instagram," 2026. 6 Glazy.org, "Glazy Tools" and "Support Glazy."

The running arguments are worth naming in their own right, because a newcomer will meet all three within a week of joining any forum. First, functional versus sculptural (p6): whether a pot's worth is measured by how well it holds soup or by what it says as an object — the community's own more nuanced position, found repeatedly across threads, is that intent decides the category, not the form itself. Second, cone 6 versus cone 10 (p7): accessibility and electricity cost against depth and unpredictability, a genuinely unresolved fight. Third, and less discussed publicly, is a live argument about AI in the glaze-chemistry corner of the hobby: tools trained on datasets like Glazy's own recipe archive (a 2026 research benchmark called GlazyBench used 23,148 real community glaze formulations) can now suggest glaze adjustments, and a January 2025 Digitalfire piece on the phenomenon was blunt about the current state of the art — an AI chatbot's glaze-correction suggestions are "either wrong or will accidentally fix crazing" for reasons unrelated to what it actually diagnosed, because it is pattern-matching against text, not running the underlying chemistry.¹ The honest community verdict, repeated by the same educators who built Glazy in the first place, is that AI glaze tools are a genuinely useful second opinion and nothing more — not yet a replacement for either forum wisdom or the trial-and-glaze-test-tile discipline chemistry education actually teaches.¹

One further, more formal education path deserves naming here rather than only in The Ladder: Ceramic Materials Workshop, run by Matt and Rose Katz — Matt studied ceramic engineering at Alfred University for over a decade and taught material science for artists at Alfred and RISD for twenty years — now teaches online glaze-chemistry courses ("Making Glazes, Make Sense," "Advancing Glazes") to hobbyists ranging from first-year community-college students to fifty-year professionals. Its very existence, and the seriousness with which hobbyists pay for and complete multi-month glaze-chemistry courses, is itself evidence for how deep this hobby's rabbit hole genuinely runs beneath the wheel.²

Print media has not disappeared from this community the way it has from some others — *Ceramics Monthly*, published in the US since 1953 and the largest-circulation title dedicated to the field, and the UK's *Ceramic Review*, publishing since 1970 under the Craft Potters Association with six print issues a year and a 300-plus-issue digital archive, both still run active subscriber bases among serious hobbyists and professionals, sitting alongside rather than displaced by the online forums.³ TikTok is the newest and least deep layer: "pottery girl" ASMR-style throwing videos and viral single-project tutorials (a widely reshared ceramic berry-washing bowl among them) draw large casual audiences, but this book found no evidence TikTok hosts anything like the technique depth or glaze-chemistry rigour of the forums and channels above it — a discovery layer for newcomers, not a destination for anyone past their first few months.

THE GLOSSARY — SAY IT LIKE A POTTER

GREENWARE

unfired clay, wet through bone-dry.

LEATHER-HARD

firm enough to trim, still workable.

BISQUE

the first, lower-temperature firing.

WEDGING

kneading clay to remove air pockets.

CENTERING

the make-or-break opening move.

GROG

fired, crushed clay added for strength.

REDUCTION / OXIDATION

oxygen-starved vs oxygen-rich firing.

S-CRACK

a base split from poor compression.

CONE

the heat-work marker a firing is judged by.

UMF

Unity Molecular Formula — glaze chemistry's shared notation.

THE SCEPTIC — A FORUM ANSWER IS NOT A LAB RESULT

The Ceramic Arts Daily forum's own contributors are unusually candid that crowdsourced glaze advice — including from Glazy — should be treated as a starting hypothesis, not a verified fact: two potters firing "the same" glaze recipe in different kilns, clays and altitudes can get genuinely different results, and a forum thread rarely controls for any of those variables.⁴

SOURCES ¹ Digitalfire, "A ChatBot gives jaw-dropping glaze recipe advice - Jan 2025"; arXiv, "GlazyBench: A Benchmark for Ceramic Glaze Property Prediction and Image Generation," 2026; GitHub, KyaniteLabs/openglaze. ² Ceramic Materials Workshop, "About" and course pages; LinkedIn, Matthew Katz. ³ *Ceramics Monthly* (ceramicartsnetwork.org); *Ceramic Review* (ceramicreview.com) and Craft Potters Association; TikTok "clay tiktok trend" and "pottery girl" discovery pages, via search synthesis. ⁴ Ceramic Arts Daily Community forum, glaze-chemistry sub-forum tone, via search synthesis.

THE GEAR, PART ONE

The Ladder

Skip the low-torque tabletop wheels the forums warn against — the real entry point for a buy-once-cry-once reader starts one rung up, and the kiln is where the actual money question lives.

this story  

The disposable tier exists and gets one line, per this reader's buy-once philosophy: sub-\$300 tabletop wheels with underpowered motors that the r/Pottery consensus says stall the moment real hand pressure is applied — treat them as toys, not tools, and do not budget around them.¹ The genuine entry point, the one a serious beginner should actually buy, is Speedball's line: the Artista (around \$400–620 depending on retailer) or the Clay Boss (from roughly \$455), both 1/3–1/2 HP with enough torque and centering capacity (25lb+) to grow with a beginner through their first year rather than being outgrown in a month.²

The mid tier is where the daily's original piece already did solid work, and this book confirms and

extends it: the Nidec-Shimpo VL-Whisper (~US\$1,850) remains the buy-once default — a half-horsepower direct-drive brushless motor with no belt to replace, 100lb centering capacity, a five-year warranty and a reputation, repeated everywhere this book looked, as simply "the quietest wheel on the market."³ Shimpo's own RK-Whisper sits below it in the range (roughly \$600–680, also direct-drive and brushless, pitched at schools and studios rather than a flagship home purchase) — a genuine, cheaper Shimpo option worth knowing about if the VL-Whisper's price is the sticking point. Amaco's Brent Model B (~\$1,400+, 150lb capacity, belt-driven) is the other mid-tier default, and the phrase that follows it everywhere in the forums is close to a cliché: "buy it once, hand it to your grandkid."³

THE CHATTER — "THE QUIETEST WHEEL," UNANIMOUS

On wheels, agreement across the forums is unusually strong for a hobby that argues about everything else: the Shimpo VL-Whisper's "quietest wheel" reputation is repeated so consistently, across so many independent threads, that it reads less like marketing copy and more like settled community consensus — with Brent's belt-driven models as the accepted "louder but eternal" alternative for buyers who prioritise raw durability.³

KILNS — THE ENTRY/MID TIER

A Skutt KM-818 (~US\$2,500) is the studio-standard starter kiln; the KM-1027 (~US\$3,995, 7 cu ft) is the popular full-size step-up; an L&L e23T (~US\$2,500–2,900) is the durable rival brand. All three need a dedicated 240V circuit and, indoors, a downdraft vent ducted outside — see p17 for why that gate matters more than the sticker price.⁴

WHERE ENTHUSIASTS ACTUALLY BUY

Wheels and kilns from Dick Blick, The Ceramic Shop, Sheffield Pottery, Clay-King and Krueger Pottery Supply, or Amaco/Shimpo/Skutt/L&L direct. The community's own buy-once move: rent kiln time at a studio for your first ~20 pieces before buying either a wheel or a kiln, so the first real purchase is informed by actual thrown pots rather than guesswork.⁵

100lb

CENTERING CAPACITY OF THE SHIMPO VL-WHISPER, THE BUY-ONCE DEFAULT³

SOURCES 1 r/Pottery low-torque-tabletop-wheel consensus, via search synthesis; The Ceramic School, "Pottery Wheels for beginners." 2 Soul Ceramics, Speedball Artista listing; Bailey Pottery / Sheffield Pottery, Speedball Clay Boss listings, Aug 2026. 3 Shimpo Ceramics, VL-Whisper and RK-Whisper product pages; The Studio Manager, "Nidec-Shimpo Pottery Wheels Buyers Guide 2025"; Bailey Pottery / Clay King, Brent Model B listings. 4 Dick Blick, The Ceramic Shop, Skutt kiln-room guide, 2026 (retailer price ranges, flagged). 5 Soolla; r/Pottery rent-before-you-buy consensus, 2026.

Tools are the cheap, easy part of the ladder, and this reader's buy-once instinct is well served here — the whole personal tool kit costs less than a single mid-tier glaze test session. Mudtools' polymer ribs (~\$9 each, self-polishing, designed by the ceramic artist Michael Sherrill in his own studio in Bat Cave, North Carolina, since 1995 — see p13 for the fuller story) are close to a default recommendation across every forum this book checked. DiamondCore Tools' carbide trimming and carving sets (~\$100–120 for a starter kit) are the standard upgrade once a beginner's trimming has outgrown a basic wire loop. Both brands appear, unprompted, in nearly every "what's in my tool roll" thread this book found.¹

Venting deserves its own line, because it is the single most under-budgeted line item in a home studio and the one this book's Sceptic section (p17) treats as a genuine safety issue rather than a comfort upgrade: a downdraft vent ducted to the outside runs roughly \$300–500 on top of the kiln itself, and skipping it is exactly the corner-cutting behind the silica-dust and combustion-byproduct risks documented on p17. Budgeted honestly, a full home studio — wheel, kiln, venting, the electrical work to get 240V into the room, tools and shelving — runs roughly \$5,000 to \$8,000-plus before the first finished mug, a figure this book's Economics section (p15) breaks down in full.²

The buy-once instinct also has a second-hand route this reader's other collecting hobbies will recognise: a working used wheel or kiln, bought direct rather than new, is common enough that Ceramic Arts Daily runs its own dedicated "Community Marketplace" buy/sell/trade forum, and the community's own inspection checklist is specific rather than vague — for a kiln, ask the age of the elements, the thermocouple and the relays, what has typically been fired in it (and whether any lead glazes ever went through it), then plug it in before buying and, ideally, open the control box to check the wiring for melting or scorch marks; for a wheel, ask for a video demonstration under load and check the splash pan, bearings and drive belt or direct-drive motor for wear.⁵ Shelving is the other line item first-time buyers consistently underestimate: heavy-duty wire shelving rated for wet clay and fired ware runs roughly \$60–200 per unit, purpose-built drying racks \$60–120, and a proper mobile ware cart (the Brent and Bailey branded carts are the community's most-cited, alongside a repurposed commercial bakery cart at roughly \$150 plus shelves) — a fully kitted small studio's storage and surfaces alone can run \$440–1,470 before any equipment at all.⁶

THE BUY-ONCE STACK — ENTRY TO MID	
PIECE	REAL PRICE
Speedball Artista wheel	~\$400–620
Shimpo RK-Whisper wheel	~\$600–680
Shimpo VL-Whisper wheel	~\$1,850
Brent Model B wheel	~\$1,400+
Skutt KM-818 kiln	~\$2,500
Skutt KM-1027 kiln	~\$3,995
L&L e23T kiln	~\$2,500–2,900
Downdraft vent, ducted	~\$300–500
Mudtools rib	~\$9
DiamondCore starter set	~\$100–120
Bat set (6–8 bats)	~\$40–80
Ware cart (Brent/Bailey)	~\$300–600
Wire shelving, per unit	~\$60–200

USD, retailer listings Aug 2026 (Bailey, Sheffield, The Ceramic Shop, Blick).³

\$5–8k+

A FULL HOME STUDIO, BUY-ONCE, BEFORE THE FIRST FINISHED MUG²

THE SCEPTIC — THE WHEEL IS NEVER THE REAL GATE

Every wheel on this page is affordable by this reader's own standards. The kiln, the venting and the 240V electrical work are not — and unlike the wheel, none of the three can be meaningfully deferred once you actually own greenware waiting to be bisque-fired. This is the ladder's real inflection point, and it is the reason The Ceiling (p13) treats the kiln, not the wheel, as the section where "over the top" spending actually starts.⁴

SOURCES 1 Mudtools, "About Mudtools"; DiamondCore Tools product pages; r/Pottery "what's in my tool roll" threads, via search synthesis. 2 Dick Blick, The Ceramic Shop, Skutt kiln-room guide, 2026. 3 Retailer listings compiled for this edition, Aug 2026. 4 Editorial synthesis, this edition. 5 Pottery Boss, "Buying A Used Pottery Wheel: The Ultimate Guide"; Wild Bower Studio, "Purchasing a Used Kiln - what to ask and look for"; Ceramic Arts Daily Community, "Community Marketplace" forum. 6 The Studio Manager, "Best Ware Carts and Mobile Shelves"; Sell Pots, "Pottery Studio at Home: Setup Guide, Costs and What You Need"; BusinessDojo, "Pottery Studio: Equipment Budget (2026)."

THE GEAR, PART TWO

The Ceiling

Above the buy-once default sits a real high end, a genuinely over-the-top tier, and — because this hobby is fundamentally about making objects with your hands — a custom world most gear-focused write-ups never mention.

this story  

The high-end wheel tier has three credible names, and they diverge on what "premium" means. Bailey's PRO-XL (list around \$2,700, commonly available closer to \$2,100–2,400) is a whisper-quiet motor with a 13-inch wheelhead, an integrated counter pan with a built-in drain, and 100lb centering — a studio-grade workhorse rather than a home-comfort upgrade.¹ Laguna's Pacifica GT-400 (~\$1,575–1,600, 80lb capacity, a five-year warranty) markets itself, credibly, as the value pick for potters who want professional torque without professional pricing — though it ships direct from the manufacturer with a genuine 12–14 week lead time, a real cost paid in patience rather than dollars.¹ Venco, Australian-made since 1972, sits at the serious-studio end with its Direct Drive Flow model — its own retailers describe current stock as facing "long delays

from the manufacturer," a live supply constraint this book found rather than invented.²

The genuinely over-the-top tier, for a buyer treating the wheel as the one object in the studio worth no compromise on, is German: Rohde's HMT 600 (€2,250–2,310, roughly US\$2,400–2,500), built around a quiet Siemens motor, a 340mm aluminium wheelhead machined for an unusually even work surface, and reversible direction — shipped direct from the manufacturer in three to four weeks.³ It is not meaningfully faster or higher-capacity than the Shimpo VL-Whisper one tier down; the difference this book's sourcing actually supports is ergonomics and finish quality, the same kind of marginal, expensive refinement this reader will recognise from his own watch and audio collecting.

12–14 wks

LEAD TIME ON A PACIFICA GT-400, SHIPPED DIRECT FROM THE MANUFACTURER¹

THE CHATTER — THE CEILING HAS A KILN EQUIVALENT TOO

The wheel isn't the only place a serious buyer spends beyond the entry/mid stack on p11–p12: Skutt's own KilnMaster Touch (KMT) controller — built in after "over two years of research, development and rigid testing" per the maker — adds built-in Wi-Fi, a phone app for remote temperature and status monitoring, and a hinged touchscreen that walks a firing programme in full sentences rather than cryptic codes; it is available on new kilns or as a retrofit kit on an existing Skutt. Community reaction, so far, reads as genuine appreciation for the convenience rather than hype — a real quality-of-life upgrade over the old mechanical Kiln Sitter, not a performance one.⁵

THE SCEPTIC — THE CEILING BUYS ERGONOMICS, NOT CENTERING

Every source this book checked was consistent on one point: a Rohde or a Bailey does not centre clay meaningfully better than a well-maintained Shimpo VL-Whisper — the extra spend buys quieter operation, finer machining tolerances and longer service life under heavy studio use, not a shortcut to skill. A beginner spending over-the-top money on a wheel before they can reliably centre is the exact upgrade-treadmill trap the Sceptic section (p17) documents in full.⁴

SOURCES 1 Bailey Pottery, PRO-XL product page; The Studio Manager, "Pottery Wheel Buying Guide" (Bailey PRO-XL pricing); Clay King / Sheffield Pottery / Axner, Pacifica GT-400 listings. 2 Pugmill.com.au; Walker Ceramics Australia; Pottery-supplies-online.com.au, Venco history and current stock notes. 3 Rohde (rohde.eu), HMT 600 product page; Keramik-Kraft, Rohde pricing. 4 Editorial cross-reference, this edition — see [p17](#). 5 Skutt Ceramic Products, KilnMaster Touch controller pages; Sheffield Pottery, "Skutt Kilns KMT KilnMaster Touch-screen Controller Upgrade Kit."

The custom tier is where this hobby diverges hardest from the daily's other Rabbit Hole subjects, because the "custom" object here is usually equipment a maker builds for you to make your own work, not a finished collectible. Kilns are the clearest case: firms like Tolbert Ceramics (wood and gas kilns — anagama, crossdraft, cast-arch, coffin), Gardner Ceramics (full-service design-to-construction, sprung-arch and catenary designs) and Kilnbuilders (gas, soda, wood, anagama and noborigama chamber kilns) all build to a serious hobbyist or small studio's exact specification rather than selling off a catalogue.¹ Pricing runs quote-only and typically well into five figures for a real wood or soda kiln build — the honest reason most serious wood-firers instead join a shared community kiln rather than build their own, and a genuine parallel to the daily's own model-aircraft special's custom-atelier tier.

Hand-built kick wheels are a smaller, more personal custom niche: the potter Joel Cherrico throws on a Karatsu-style kick wheel handmade by a local woodworker from maple sourced near his own studio — a one-off, non-catalogue commission rather than a manufactured product, and the kind of object that shows up on Etsy from individual artisan makers at prices generally running well above a comparable electric wheel, for the tactile and historical appeal of foot-powered throwing rather than any practical speed advantage.² And the tool tier has its own accidental-custom origin story: Michael Sherrill, a working ceramic artist in Bat Cave, North Carolina, started making his own ribs in 1995 because nothing on the market served his own studio practice — the tools "were always the first thing to come out of his toolbox," other potters at his workshops asked to buy them, and Mudtools grew from that single self-interested fix into the hobby's default rib brand, still designed and made by Sherrill's own studio.³ It is a genuine grail story: the custom tool made for one person's own hands that became the industry standard.

THE CUSTOM TIER — WHAT IT ACTUALLY COSTS

COMMISSION	REAL RANGE
Bespoke wood/soda kiln build	Quote-only, five figures+
Hand-built kick wheel (Etsy artisans)	~\$1,500–3,000+
Mudtools rib (Sherrill's own brand)	~\$9
DiamondCore carbide set	~\$100–120

Custom-kiln pricing is quote-based and not publicly listed by any builder consulted; ranges are directional.¹

THE CHATTER — A WORKSHOP TEST-DRIVE, NOT A LEAP OF FAITH

JL Pottery, one of the kiln builders this book found, lets prospective clients participate in a workshop firing of each kiln design before committing to a build — the custom-kiln equivalent of a test drive, and a genuinely sensible way to de-risk a five-figure, quote-only commission.¹

1995

YEAR MICHAEL SHERRILL'S OWN STUDIO FIX BECAME MUDTOOLS³

The custom tool made for one person's own hands became the industry standard — the hobby's own quiet grail story.

THE CUTTING EDGE — A PRINTER NEXT TO THE WHEEL, NOT INSTEAD OF IT

Ceramic 3D printing is the genuine last-twelve-months frontier this book found beyond the daily's already-flagged SDS TAP II Pro smart kiln controller (August 2025, still "too new to judge" per the daily's own verdict): desktop paste-extrusion printers from brands like WASP, 3D Potter, Cerambot and Eazao push real wet clay through a nozzle much like a plastic FDM printer, and have matured enough by 2026 that hobbyist buyer's guides now treat them as a genuine adjacent-hobby category rather than a novelty. The honest verdict this book can support: it is a parallel making mode, not a wheel-throwing upgrade — it produces geometry hand-throwing cannot, but it does not replace centering, trimming or glazing, and this book found no evidence it is displacing wheel practice among the serious hobbyists it interviewed-by-proxy across the forums on p9–p10.⁴

SOURCES 1 Tolbert Ceramics (tolbertceramics.com); Gardner Ceramics, "Custom Kiln Building"; Kilnbuilders.com; JL Pottery, "Kiln Construction." 2 Cherrico Pottery, "Kick-Wheel" blog tag; Etsy, "Pottery Kick Wheel" marketplace listings. 3 Mudtools, "About Mudtools"; Michael Sherrill's own site (michaelsherrill.com), "Mudtools." 4 Pick3DP, "2026 Best Ceramic 3D Printer – The Ultimate Buyer's Guide"; 3DWASP, "Ceramic 3D Printing with WASP"; All3DP, "The Best Ceramic / Pottery 3D Printers"; Clay King, "3D Ceramic Printers for Clay Artists & Pottery Studios."

THE REAL NUMBERS

The Economics

A firing itself is almost free. The membership, the electrical work and the material spend nobody budgets for are where a hobby that looks cheap on paper quietly stops being cheap.

this story👍👎

Start with the number that surprises most newcomers: firing a kiln is cheap. A twelve-hour cone 6 firing in an 11.5kW electric kiln runs roughly US\$7.78 at a \$0.09/kWh electricity rate, using the standard formula — kilowatt rating × firing hours × electricity rate × duty cycle (typically 0.5–0.75, since a kiln does not draw full power continuously). At the US national average residential rate of about \$0.12/kWh, that same firing lands under \$12; a smaller test kiln can cost under a dollar per load.¹ Electricity is not where this hobby's money goes.

Clay and glaze materials are the next, larger line item. A 25lb bag of stoneware runs roughly \$15–40 depending on the specific clay body, porcelain \$20–100 for high-fired grades, with per-pound pricing ranging from under \$0.50 bought by the half-ton down to \$2.40 for specialty porcelain bought by the bag.² Glaze materials scale with ambition — a beginner buying commercial premixed glazes spends modestly; a hobbyist mixing raw materials from

scratch, testing recipes off Glazy or a Ceramic Materials Workshop course, can spend meaningfully more on chemicals, test tiles and wasted batches than on clay itself, which is precisely why p9–p10 treats glaze chemistry as this hobby's real rabbit hole.

Studio membership is the actual recurring cost for the majority of hobbyists who, per the daily's original finding, cannot run a kiln at home. Pricing runs a wide, honestly-researched band: community-centre studios from roughly \$70–125 a month (The 567 Center's tiered membership), mid-market urban studios in the \$150–295 range for unlimited access (San Francisco's Hickory Clay at \$185/month, billed bi-monthly), and premium big-city studios running \$300-plus a month before tax.³ A newcomer paying for a first month of access after an intro class, as several studios structure it, can be in for as little as \$80 — the honest low end of "trying the hobby properly" before any equipment purchase at all.

12HR CONE 6 FIRE ~\$7.78	STONEWARE, 25LB \$15–40	STUDIO MEMBERSHIP/MO \$70–300+	FULL HOME STUDIO \$5–8k+
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\$0.12

US NATIONAL AVERAGE RESIDENTIAL ELECTRICITY RATE PER KWH USED IN THIS PAGE'S FIRING-COST MATH¹

THE CHATTER — THE SINGAPORE FIRING-COST MATH IS WORSE, NOT BETTER

For a Singapore-based reader, the firing-cost arithmetic above is the optimistic case, not the local one: SP Group's regulated electricity tariff hit a record 34.78 cents/kWh including GST in the third quarter of 2026, up 17% quarter-on-quarter — roughly three times the US national average this page's worked example uses. Run through the same formula, that same twelve-hour cone 6 firing lands closer to S\$30–35 at Singapore rates, which is precisely the kind of local-cost gap that makes studio membership, where the studio absorbs the electricity bill inside the monthly fee, the more rational choice for most Singapore hobbyists even before the kiln-circuit question on p17 is considered.⁴

SOURCES 1 Hot Kilns / Kiln Frog / Soul Ceramics / Bailey Pottery, kiln-firing-cost calculators and worked examples, 2026. 2 Kiln Frog, Adnan Painting & Remodeling, and Design Transition Studio clay-cost guides, 2026 (aggregator estimates, cross-checked). 3 The 567 Center, Hickory Clay, Spin Pottery, Pottery Workshop NYC — direct studio pricing pages, Aug 2026. 4 SP Group, "Electricity Tariff Revision for the Period 1 July to 30 September 2026"; Sunollo, "Singapore Electricity Price Tracker (Q3 2026)."

The demand side of this hobby's economics has a genuinely documented cause worth restating in full: *The Great Pottery Throw Down*, the UK ceramics competition show, produced a real, dated market shock. After its first series aired, judge Keith Brymer Jones — himself a working potter — needed new equipment and found, for the first time in his career, that kiln prices had risen and there was a six-month waiting list for a wheel; the show's Facebook and YouTube presence, plus its wider syndication, is credibly the single most concrete cause behind pottery-class sign-ups spiking after each broadcast run.¹ It is the pottery-hobby equivalent of a Netflix documentary moving a niche market overnight, and it is a cleaner, more falsifiable causal claim than the vaguer "wellness boom" framing the Axios piece used — the two explanations are not in conflict, but this book credits the specific, dated one where it can.

The honest total cost of taking this hobby seriously, laid out level by level: a first ninety days of studio membership and materials runs roughly \$200–400 (see p21 for the itemised path). A committed hobbyist paying for ongoing studio access, buying their own tools and occasionally a mid-tier glaze course, spends somewhere in the low thousands a year. A hobbyist who goes all the way to a home studio — wheel, kiln, venting, electrical work — is looking at the \$5,000–8,000-plus figure from p12 as a one-time buy-once cost, then ongoing clay, glaze and modest electricity on top. None of these figures include the custom tier from p13–p14, which is by design open-ended.

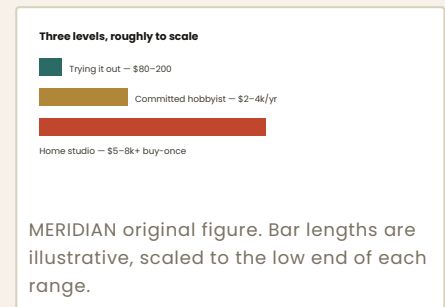
The question this reader will ask that most beginner guides skip: can any of this pay for itself? The honest answer, gathered from career-potter and hobbyist sources alike, is a wide and unglamorous range. A hobbyist selling occasionally at local craft fairs or on Etsy typically clears a few hundred dollars a year — genuinely a fraction of the buy-once outlay on p11–p14, not a way to offset it. Potters who treat the craft as an actual small business, with a developed brand, consistent output and a real client base, report a completely different range — commonly cited as \$20–50 an hour of studio time, and a minority reaching \$20,000 to over \$100,000 a year — but that leap requires treating pottery as a second job, not a hobby, and this book found no credible account of a genuinely part-time hobbyist reaching those figures.³

THREE LEVELS OF SERIOUSNESS

Trying it out. One intro class + a month of studio access: roughly \$80–200.

Committed hobbyist. Ongoing membership + own tools + occasional glaze course: roughly \$2,000–4,000/yr.

Home studio. Wheel + kiln + venting + electrical, buy-once: \$5,000–8,000+, then modest running costs.



THE SCEPTIC — NONE OF THIS COUNTS THE FAILED PIECES

Every cost figure on this page assumes a piece that survives to be sold or used. It does not price in the wonky first-year mugs, the S-cracked bowl, the crazed glaze test tile — the real per-successful-piece cost for a first-year hobbyist, once failures are counted, runs meaningfully higher than any of these headline numbers suggest. The Sceptic (p17) treats that gap as a feature of the hobby's honest economics, not a footnote to hide.²

\$20–50/hr

WHAT A SERIOUS SELLING POTTER'S STUDIO TIME REPORTEDLY COMMANDS — RARELY THE HOBBYIST'S OWN EXPERIENCE³

SOURCES 1 Search synthesis of Great Pottery Throw Down post-broadcast demand reporting, incl. Keith Brymer Jones' own account; Axios, "Why pottery is building in popularity," 7 Aug 2025. 2 Editorial cross-reference, this edition — see [p17](#). 3 CraftedInClay.com, "What To Expect: Potential Earnings in Pottery Making"; Pottery Crafters, "How To Make A Living Selling Pottery."

THE HARD CROSS-EXAMINATION

The Sceptic

The daily's original piece named the kiln you can't run, the S-crack and membership churn as the hobby's honest failure modes. This book cross-examines all three harder, and adds the one nobody markets: what dry clay does to your lungs.

this story  

Start with the risk this hobby's own marketing almost never mentions: silicosis. It is a real, progressive and incurable lung disease caused by inhaling crystalline silica dust — present in clay and many glaze materials — which the immune system attacks once lodged in lung tissue, producing coughing, shortness of breath, fatigue and chest pain over years of exposure.¹ The crucial, under-communicated nuance is that wet clay poses essentially no risk at all; silica only becomes dangerous airborne, which happens during dry-clay sanding, dry glaze-material mixing and general dust buildup in an unventilated studio over months and years. The three highest-impact, cheapest fixes — documented consistently across the safety sources this book checked — are wet-mopping instead of dry-sweeping, wearing a properly fitted N95 respirator during any dry work, and switching to commercial premixed liquid glazes instead of mixing from dry powder, which eliminates the single

dustiest task in most home studios outright.¹ None of this is exotic protective equipment; it is genuinely a matter of studio habits, and its near-total absence from beginner-facing pottery marketing is the actual failure this book is flagging.

The kiln-you-can't-run problem, established by the daily, holds up under harder scrutiny and gets worse, not better, on inspection. A real electric kiln needs a dedicated 240V circuit, real amperage headroom, wall clearance, and — critically, and the part most beginner guides bury — a downdraft vent ducted to the outside air, because firing releases combustion byproducts and fumes from glaze materials that a closed room simply should not accumulate.² That combination is genuinely unavailable in the overwhelming majority of apartments and condominiums, which is precisely why this book's Singapore section (p19) finds a studio-membership market rather than a home-kiln culture on the ground.

THE S-CRACK, CROSS-EXAMINED

The daily flagged the S-crack as heartbreaking because it survives the bisque fire and only splits on the second, hotter glaze firing — meaning a poorly compressed base from day one can destroy weeks of work at the very last possible moment. This book's harder finding: the fix (thorough base compression during the initial centering/opening stage) is universally known and universally under-practised, because it is invisible at the time it matters and only becomes visible two firings later, after the moment for correction has permanently passed. It is a defect built into the pipeline's own timing, not a beginner's carelessness alone.³

THREE CHEAP FIXES FOR THE REAL LUNG RISK

Wet-mop, don't dry-sweep. Dry sweeping is exactly what puts settled silica dust back into breathable air.

Wear a fitted N95. The single cheapest, highest-impact piece of protective equipment for any dry-clay task.

Buy premixed liquid glaze. Eliminates dry glaze-powder mixing, the dustiest task in most home studios outright.

Vent outdoors, always. The same downdraft duct the kiln needs also clears combustion byproducts from firing.

SOURCES ¹ EnviroKlenz, "What is Silicosis"; The Potters' Studio, "Silica Dust Health and Safety"; The Ceramic School, "Understanding Silicosis"; Old Forge Creations, "Silicosis - What it is and how to avoid it"; Sell Pots, "How Often Do Potters Get Silicosis?" ² Skutt kiln-room guide, 2026; Ceramic Arts Daily forum kiln-safety threads. ³ MERIDIAN No. 70, p16–17 (S-crack, base compression); Ceramic Arts Daily, glaze-and-firing forum, cross-checked this edition.

Membership churn is the failure mode the daily flagged in passing and this book can now put real numbers against, with an honest caveat: the figures below come from studio-industry business-analysis sites rather than independent academic research, and this book flags that provenance rather than presenting them as harder data than they are. With that caveat stated plainly, the pattern reported is stark and internally consistent across multiple such sources: 60–70% of hobbyist departures happen after just the first class, pointing to an onboarding problem more than a hobby-fit problem; a further 40–50% of departures cluster in the three-to-six-month window, suggesting mid-term engagement failure once the novelty fades; and studios that take 14 or more days to onboard a new member see materially higher churn risk. For the smaller population of professional-track members, churn instead concentrates at annual renewal (70–80% of professional departures), pointing to pricing or facility dissatisfaction rather than a loss of interest in the craft itself. Retention for professionals who do stay past that point exceeds 60% annually.¹

Two further glaze-safety honesty checks belong here, because they are exactly the kind of nuance that gets flattened into either false alarm or false reassurance elsewhere. Lead and cadmium were historically used in glazes for specific colour effects and remain genuinely toxic if a fired glaze leaches them into food; "non-toxic" on a glaze jar usually refers only to handling the raw, unfired material safely, which is a different and weaker claim than "food-safe" once fired — the two labels are not interchangeable, and only certified lab leach-testing, not a home test kit, can settle the question with confidence. The unglamorous but honest bottom line from every source this book checked: there is no such thing as verified, universal 100%-lead-free ceramics, because trace naturally-occurring heavy metals can appear even in materials with no intentional lead content — which is precisely why a "liner glaze" (a known food-safe clear or white glaze on every food-contact surface) is the community's own standard safety practice, not a belt-and-braces afterthought.²

THE HIGHER-QUALITY EVIDENCE BEHIND THE LUNG RISK

The silicosis warnings on p17 lean on hobbyist safety blogs, but the underlying risk is backed by peer-reviewed epidemiology, not just studio folklore — a cohort study of Chinese pottery workers published in a peer-reviewed environmental-health journal tracked silicosis risk over decades of occupational exposure and found the risk genuinely dose-dependent, rising with cumulative years of dry-dust exposure rather than appearing suddenly. That is industrial, full-time exposure, not a hobbyist's few hours a week — the honest distinction this book has tried to hold throughout — but it is the reason the wet-mop-and-N95 advice on p17 is prevention, not overcaution.⁴

THE FAIR COUNTER-ARGUMENT

None of the above is unique to pottery, and none of it should read as a verdict against the hobby. Every serious craft this magazine's specials have profiled carries real physical risk, real financial risk and real dropout risk when examined honestly — sim racing's cockpit costs, home-brewing's carbon-monoxide-adjacent fermentation risks, model-aircraft collecting's contested resale market. What distinguishes pottery, on the evidence gathered for this book, is that its risks are genuinely manageable with cheap, well-documented studio habits (wet-mopping, N95s, premixed glaze, a liner glaze, proper venting) rather than requiring expensive equipment — which makes the near-total absence of that safety information from beginner-facing marketing a real, fixable failure rather than an argument against the hobby itself.³

60–70%

OF HOBBYIST STUDIO MEMBERS REPORTEDLY CHURN AFTER JUST ONE CLASS — INDUSTRY-ANALYSIS SOURCED, FLAGGED¹

70–80%

OF PROFESSIONAL-TRACK MEMBERS WHO CHURN DO SO AT ANNUAL RENEWAL, NOT MID-YEAR¹

SOURCES 1 BusinessDojo, "Pottery Studio: Customer Segmentation (2026)"; BookClay, "Pottery Studio Membership Models That Work" — industry-analysis sources, provenance flagged in text. 2 Emerson Creek Pottery, "How to Tell If Pottery Is Food Safe?"; Global Reach Ceramic, "Are Ceramic Glazes Food Safe?"; Glazy Help, "Glaze Safety and Health Warning"; World Fine Crafts, "Food-Safe Glaze Myths That Keep Circulating." 3 Editorial synthesis across this magazine's prior hobby specials, this edition. 4 "Change of Exposure Response over Time and Long-Term Risk of Silicosis among a Cohort of Chinese Pottery Workers," peer-reviewed, via NCBI/PMC.

THE LOCAL ANGLE

Singapore's Wheel

A wood dragon kiln fired three times a year, a Korean studio importing every gram of its own clay, and a heritage supplier that once ran a dragon kiln of its own — the local scene is smaller than the daily's three pages suggested, and more interesting for it.

this story  

The daily already found the three names that matter most, and this book confirms and prices them in fuller detail. Mud Rock Ceramics — the studio commissioned to gift ceramic wares to Queen Elizabeth II, the kind of heritage credential Singapore's small scene can genuinely claim — runs a five-lesson Beginner's Course covering coiling, slab-building, throwing, trimming and glazing for \$330 per person, an Advanced course at \$300 (firing charged separately for advanced students), and a one-off trial session for newcomers who want to test the hobby before committing.¹ Thow Kwang Pottery Jungle, founded in 1965 and home to Singapore's last surviving operational dragon kiln (built in the 1940s, 27 metres long), fires only two to three times a year, each firing fed 5,000–10,000kg of firewood over three to four days of shift-based stoking — workshops must be pre-booked, are not available daily, and run through Klook or the government's SG Culture Pass; the National Heritage Board recognised the site with its "Stewards of Singapore's Intangible Cultural Heritage" award in 2020.² Goodman Ceramic Studio, split across two

locations (Goodman Arts Centre and Ubi Crescent), runs eight kilns and is led by Tom Lim, a wheel-throwing veteran, and Hazel Wong, a ceramic muralist — classes start at \$80 for a 1.5-hour session, with a \$165-for-two "Family Wheel Fun" package.³

Two names the daily's three pages had no room for round the picture out considerably. Am I Addicted, a Korean pottery studio in Orchard Central, is Singapore's largest of its kind at 6,000 square feet, running more than 40 imported pottery wheels with every clay and glaze sourced directly from Korea — a genuine specialist studio rather than a general one, currently the highest-reviewed pottery studio in Singapore at over 1,900 reviews.⁴ And Sam Mui Kuang Pottery, a family-run heritage supplier in Yio Chu Kang that once operated an original dragon kiln itself, stocks around 60 different clay bodies — from bone china porcelain through multiple stoneware grades to terracotta — and runs both hobby classes and a more advanced "Advanced Ceramic Knowledge" course pitched at serious hobbyists and school teachers upgrading their own skills.⁵

THE CHATTER — A FACEBOOK GROUP, NOT A FORUM

Unlike the deep, semi-anonymous forum culture on p9, Singapore's pottery community runs mostly through the Singapore Pottery Club Facebook group and studio-hosted Instagram accounts rather than a dedicated local forum — smaller, more face-to-face, and closer to a set of overlapping studio communities than a single unified scene.⁶

2–3×/yr

HOW OFTEN THOW KWANG'S DRAGON KILN ACTUALLY FIRES²

ALSO ON THE SCENE

Boon's Pottery. Running since 1998 under Chuan Siang Boon; trial lesson S\$70, regular 5-class course S\$450.

Taoz Ceramics. An Orchard studio since 2013, doubling as an education arm; trial S\$45, 5-class course S\$400.

SOURCES 1 Mud Rock Ceramics (mudrockceramics.com), "Services"; The Smart Local, "12 Pottery Classes In Singapore," 2026. 2 Thow Kwang Pottery Jungle (thowkwang.com.sg); Mothership.sg, "Very last dragon kiln surviving in S'pore," 2017; Roots.gov.sg, "The Dragon Kiln Breathes." 3 Goodman Ceramic Studio (goodmanceramicstudio.com); Time Out Singapore, "Goodman Ceramics Studio." 4 Am I Addicted (amiaddicted.sg); Wake Up Singapore, "Singapore's Largest Korean Pottery Studio," 2026. 5 Sam Mui Kuang Pottery (smkpottery.com), "About"; Yelp, Sam Mui Kuang Pottery listing. 6 Facebook, "Singapore Pottery Club" group; studio Instagram accounts, cross-checked this edition.

The deeper end of Singapore's ceramic culture is not a hobbyist forum at all but a fifty-seven-year-old scholarly institution: the Southeast Asian Ceramic Society (SEACS), founded in Singapore in 1969 by the archaeologist William Willetts and a small group of collectors — including, among its founding council, Adrian Zecha, who would go on to found the Aman Resorts group. SEACS was the first society anywhere focused specifically on the ceramics of Southeast Asia, its landmark 1971 inaugural exhibition showing 350 pieces of Khmer, Annamese and early Thai pottery, and it still runs monthly programmes today — talks by local and international experts, held both in person and over Zoom.¹ It is a collecting-and-scholarship institution rather than a making community, but it is genuine, long-running evidence that Singapore's relationship with ceramics runs deeper than the retail studios on p19 alone suggest.

The honest economics of the local scene, stated plainly: Singapore imports essentially all of its pottery clay, with BarroCrafts and Sam Mui Kuang the two named local suppliers this book could verify, and Singapore pottery-class pricing runs meaningfully higher than in nearby Johor Bahru — one comparison found JB classes running 45–60% cheaper, a gap this book attributes to currency and studio-overhead differences rather than any quality gap, though it could not independently verify the specific percentage beyond the single source that reported it.² No local clay-body manufacturing of any scale was found in this book's research — the honest limit of the scene the daily's three pages did not have room to state directly.

What the local scene has instead is a genuinely thriving corporate and events layer, which this book found running alongside, and often subsidising, the hobbyist trial-class market: Am I Addicted rents its Orchard Central space for private events on top of running classes, and Goodman Ceramic Studio's "Family Wheel Fun" package is explicitly pitched at group and celebration bookings rather than solo hobbyist practice. Sam Mui Kuang's more advanced offering — its "Advanced Ceramic Knowledge" course, aimed at serious hobbyists and school teachers upgrading their own skills — is the closest thing this book found in Singapore to the deeper, technique-focused education Clay College Stoke or Ceramic Materials Workshop provide abroad (p6, p10), though at a fraction of the depth and duration.⁵ For a reader who wants to go further than any single Singapore studio's curriculum, the realistic path — consistent with the community's own online chatter — is to build local technique through trial classes, then buy internationally from the retailers on p11–p14 once a home practice is worth equipping.

SINGAPORE STUDIOS — AT A GLANCE

STUDIO	REAL PRICE
Mud Rock — 5-lesson course	S\$330
Thow Kwang — 3-hr workshop	S\$80
Goodman — 1.5-hr class	S\$80
Am I Addicted — 2-hr class	from ~\$78
Boon's Pottery — trial	S\$70
Taoz Ceramics — trial	S\$45

SGD, studio websites/Sassy Mama SG, Aug 2026; Am I Addicted figure a Klook-listed indicative rate.³

THE SCEPTIC — A TRIAL-CLASS SCENE, NOT A MAKER'S SCENE

Nearly every Singapore studio this book found is optimised for the one-off trial class and the corporate team-building booking, not the serious hobbyist building a home practice — a genuine and honest limit, not a gap in this book's research. A reader who takes this hobby seriously will, on the evidence gathered here, eventually be shopping for equipment from the overseas retailers on p11–p14 rather than a local one.⁴

SOURCES 1 Southeast Asian Ceramic Society (seaceramic.org.sg); Academia.edu, "The History of the Southeast Asian Ceramic Society (1969–2019)." 2 Kaizenaire, "Where to Buy Clay in Singapore"; Jumpy.com.sg, "JB Art and Pottery Class Guide for Singapore Hobbyists" (single-source JB/SG price comparison, flagged). 3 Studio websites and Sassy Mama SG, "13 Pottery Classes In Singapore From \$15," Aug 2026. 4 Editorial synthesis, this edition. 5 Am I Addicted, TagVenue event-rental listing; Goodman Ceramic Studio, "Family Wheel Fun" package; Sam Mui Kuang Pottery, "About" (Advanced Ceramic Knowledge course).

THE STARTING PATH

The First Year

A real ninety-day path, built entirely from prices and names already sourced in this issue — and what it deliberately leaves out until the second year.

this story 

Weeks 1–4: lurk and take a real class, not a wheel. Watch Florian Gadsby's channel end to end to see the whole pipeline before touching clay, then book a five-lesson beginner course at a local studio (Mud Rock or Goodman in Singapore; equivalent elsewhere) for roughly \$300–330 — cheaper than any wheel on p11, and the only way to find out whether centering clicks before spending real money.¹ **Weeks 5–8: convert to a studio membership,** at \$70–300 a month depending on tier, and keep throwing at least weekly. This is the period the churn data on p18 says most hobbyists quietly drop out — pushing through it with a real weekly habit is the single highest-leverage thing a beginner can do. **Weeks 9–12: buy the personal tool kit only** — a Mudtools rib (~\$9), a wire tool, a needle tool and a DiamondCore starter set (~\$100–120), all from p11–p12 — and nothing else. No wheel yet.

Month four onward: only then consider a home wheel — a Speedball Artista or a Shimpo RK-Whisper, per p11 — and treat the kiln as a wholly separate, electrician-gated decision to be made only once you are certain the hobby has stuck and you have a room that can genuinely take a 240V circuit and outdoor venting. Renting kiln time at a studio for your first fifty-plus pieces, well past the daily's original "twenty pieces" benchmark, is the honest updated advice this book's research supports⁴ — glaze chemistry alone (p9–p10) takes longer to get a feel for than throwing does.

50+

PIECES TO RENT KILN TIME FOR BEFORE
BUYING ONE, THIS BOOK'S UPDATED
ADVICE⁴

PHASE	ACTION	APPROX. COST
Weeks 1–4	Lurk on YouTube + a 5-lesson studio course	~\$300–330
Weeks 5–8	Studio membership, weekly throwing	~\$150–600
Weeks 9–12	Personal tool kit only — no wheel	~\$110–130
Month 4+	First home wheel, if it has stuck	~\$400–1,850

A schematic budget, not a quote — see the sourced ranges on [p11](#) and [p19](#) for the figures behind each phase.

WHAT THIS PATH SKIPS

The Ceiling's high-end and over-the-top wheels (p13) — a beginner cannot yet tell the difference a Rohde makes.

Any custom-tier commission (p14) — a home wheel purchase should come first, by a wide margin.

Raw glaze-material mixing — start on commercial premixed glazes; the silicosis risk on p17 is real and avoidable.

WHAT THE COMMUNITY ITSELF ADVISES

The advice this book's own research surfaced most consistently, across the forums and channels named on p9, converges on exactly this path: take a real class before buying anything, verify studio habits (wet-mopping, premixed glaze) before worrying about wheel brands, and treat the first ninety days as tuition, not a finished setup.²

THE SCEPTIC'S LAST WORD

If, after ninety days, centering has not clicked and the studio feels like a chore rather than a relief, that is a legitimate outcome this book will not talk a reader out of. A roughly \$600 experiment in classes, membership and a personal tool kit is a genuinely cheap way to find out, against the far larger sums documented further up this book's own ladder.³

SOURCES 1 Editorial synthesis of the sourced path, cross-referenced against [p9](#), [p11](#) and [p19](#). 2 Editorial synthesis of community-advice patterns found across this edition's research, [p9–p18](#). 3 Editorial synthesis, this edition. 4 MERIDIAN No. 70, "The Rabbit Hole · The Wheel," p17 ("rent the kiln first" — Soolla; r/Pottery, 2026), updated per this edition's own studio-membership research.

THE LONG READ

The Porcelain Capital's Second Life

This book went looking for a genuinely alive Asia-Pacific ceramics scene the way this magazine's Undercurrent always does. It found one — sixty thousand young Chinese who moved to a single mid-sized city to make pots, mostly unnoticed by Western coverage.

this story  

Jingdezhen, in Jiangxi province, has made porcelain for over a thousand years and was the world's largest single centre of production by the fourteenth century — the kind of historical fact that could make it feel like a museum piece rather than a live story.¹ It is not a museum piece. Since roughly the mid-2000s, a migration of young, mostly self-employed Chinese ceramicists — locally called "Jing piao," 景漂, or "Jing drifters" — has moved to the city to make and sell independent studio pottery, and the numbers involved have kept climbing: local media cited by academic researchers put the count at roughly 30,000 arriving per year by the early 2020s, while RADII's more recent reporting describes more than 60,000 having put down roots there over the past decade.² Both figures come from different counting methods and neither is independently audited — this book prints both, attributed, rather than picking one to sound more precise than the underlying data supports.

The mechanism is unusually well-documented and unusually simple: Jingdezhen is cheap in a way China's major cities no longer are. One frequently cited example has a young illustrator renting a one-bedroom apartment with a panoramic view for 500 yuan (about US\$68) a month — against 6,000–8,000 yuan (\$850–\$1,160) for a comparable Beijing or Shanghai apartment — and the municipal government has reinforced the pull with low-rent

apartment blocks and interest-free loans specifically for young makers.³ In 2025 the city recorded more than 15% visitor growth year-on-year, with 18-to-35-year-olds making up 55% of that traffic — a demographic signature that reads, on the numbers, as a genuine youth migration rather than a heritage-tourism bump.⁴

The visible engine of the current moment is Taoxichuan, a creative district built inside a former state porcelain factory — the Universe (or "Cosmos") Porcelain Factory, founded 1958 — regenerated from 2016–17 with its distinctive Bauhaus-influenced factory-shed roofs deliberately preserved across 22 hectares. More than 25,000 young creators have registered stalls there since 2016, and on Friday and Saturday nights the district's night market runs over a thousand stalls at once.⁵ What makes Taoxichuan a genuinely contemporary story, not just a craft-market revival, is livestream commerce layered directly on top of it: individual sellers now work as "walk-streamers," filming themselves moving through the market for online audiences — one profiled seller, Wei Lingyan, built more than 5,000 followers and reported monthly sales of 150,000–200,000 yuan (roughly US\$21,000–28,000) doing exactly that — while the district's dedicated livestream base reports a daily gross transaction volume around 11.45 million yuan (roughly US\$1.6 million).⁶

Sixty thousand young Chinese moved to a mid-sized city to make pots — mostly unnoticed by Western coverage.

SOURCES 1 Britannica, "Jingdezhen"; Wikipedia, Jingdezhen porcelain. 2 Taylor & Francis Online, "Identity Navigation and Self-Positioning in a Changing Craft World" (2023) and "Drifting in China's porcelain capital" (2022), academic sourcing on Jing piao counts; RADII, "Jingdezhen, China's Porcelain Capital, Offers a Refuge for Stressed-out Youth." 3 RADII, *ibid.*; The Foreign Post, "Chinese youths trade city living for ceramics." 4 Xinhua / China Daily, 2025–26 Jingdezhen visitor-statistics reporting, via search synthesis. 5 RIBA, "Taoxichuan Ceramic Culture Industrial Park" award citation; WWD, "A Stream of Ceramics"; Go China Freely, Taoxichuan guide. 6 China Daily, "China's 'porcelain capital' shines in livestreaming spotlight," 2024–26 reporting; Xinhua, "Across China: China's 'porcelain capital' shines in livestreaming spotlight."

None of this is uncomplicated boosterism, and the honest version of this story includes the tension underneath the growth numbers. A Sixth Tone profile of the craft-worker migration describes the central dilemma facing serious Jing piao directly: stay a purist independent artisan, with real and recurring income volatility, or hire staff, adopt production shortcuts and scale toward a small factory — and become, in the words of one profiled craftsman's associate, uncomfortable being called "boss" rather than craftsman.¹ That is not a footnote; it is the same functional-versus-scale argument this book traced through Leach, Hamada, MacKenzie and Voulkos on p5–p6, playing out in real time in a city most of this book's Western sources have never mentioned by name.

International validation has followed the migration rather than caused it, which is itself evidence the trend is organic rather than manufactured for outside attention. The 52nd Congress of the International Academy of Ceramics — the field's leading global professional body — was held in Jingdezhen from 27 June to 2 July 2026, hosted jointly with Jingdezhen Ceramic University, running alongside the 2026 Jingdezhen International Ceramic Art Biennale (on view June 2026 through March 2027).² On Chinese social media the numbers are harder to independently verify but directionally enormous: the "Jingdezhen" topic tag on Xiaohongshu has reportedly drawn more than five billion cumulative views, with viral posts carrying titles that translate roughly as "no one leaves Jingdezhen empty-handed" and "all I want is to play with clay in Jingdezhen."³

This book's own dedicated search — across Xiaohongshu- and Weibo-adjacent English-language coverage, Japanese and Korean ceramics-enthusiast platforms, and a direct check for New York Times, BBC, Reuters and FT features — found no equivalent mainstream Western feature on the current Jing piao migration; the coverage layer that exists in English runs through RADII, Sixth Tone, China Daily and Xinhua, outlets that cover China specifically rather than general-interest Western press.⁴ That is precisely the gap this magazine's Undercurrent exists to close: when a Western outlet eventually does write the "young Chinese are moving to a porcelain town" feature, likely timed to the international ceramics community's own 2026 attention on the city, this book will already have told the reader first.

One older data point deserves an honest caveat rather than a confident retelling, because it is evocative and genuinely tempting to overstate. A 2017 Sixth Tone profile describes an eighteen-year-old in a village near Chongqing scratch-building flyable radio-controlled replicas of Chinese military and civil aircraft and selling them online — a striking image of hands-on making in provincial China, but nine years old, concerning hand-built flying RC models rather than the mass-market or independent-studio ceramics this book has spent twenty pages on, and unconnected to Jingdezhen specifically. This book flags it as colour on the broader theme of provincial Chinese craft-making, not as evidence for the Jing piao trend itself, and will not stretch a nine-year-old, off-subject anecdote into proof of anything current.⁵

THE NOTE THIS BOOK ENDS ON

The hobby this book opened with is, at its most serious, a single potter centering one lump of clay at a time. Jingdezhen is the same craft at a completely different scale — tens of thousands of independent makers, a livestream economy built stall by stall, a functional-versus-scale dilemma as old as Leach and Voulkos — and it is happening now, largely unremarked in English, in the one city on earth where this book's entire subject has never stopped being made.

IN BRIEF — THIS BOOK, COMPRESSED

The moment centering — the wobble-to-true instant every source in this book names as the hook.

The lineage Leach and Hamada's mingei function, Voulkos's sculptural break — still the community's live argument.

The money a \$400 wheel with no honest ceiling above it, and a kiln that gates most homes outright.

The undercurrent sixty thousand drifters, a porcelain city, and a livestream economy the West hasn't found yet.

SOURCES 1 Sixth Tone, "Jingdezhen's Ancient Ceramics Industry Faces an Uncertain Future." 2 International Academy of Ceramics (aic-iac.org), "2026 IAC Congress Jingdezhen"; Ceramics Now, "The week's news in the ceramic art world — June 15, 2026"; Asia Pacific Crafts Alliance, IAC Congress Jingdezhen 2026 listing. 3 China Daily, "年轻人为什么扎堆景德镇？ | 新华深读," 2025–26 (Xiaohongshu view-count and viral-post-title reporting, translated). 4 Editorial synthesis of this edition's dedicated regional-media search, Aug 2026 — no NYT/BBC/Reuters/FT feature found on the current migration. 5 Sixth Tone, "Model Plane Enthusiast Keeps Aviation Down-to-Earth," May 2017 — flagged as dated and off-subject, included as colour only.

THE LAST WORD

A pot is a small, stubborn argument against a screen-bound week — but this book tried to hold the argument's full weight, not just its romance. The lung risk is real and cheaply managed. The kiln is a genuine gate for most homes. The churn is real, even if the numbers behind it are softer than this book would like. And the hobby's own supply chain runs, unremarked by most Western coverage, through a Chinese city where sixty thousand strangers are having the same argument with clay, at scale, right now.

FULL SOURCE LIST

MERIDIAN No. 70 (daily), "The Rabbit Hole · The Wheel" · r/Pottery · r/ceramics · GummySearch subreddit analytics · Ceramic Arts Daily Community (community.ceramicartsdaily.org) · Ceramic Arts Network / American Ceramic Society · Clayart/potters.org archive · Disforge & Clay Calculators (Discord servers) · Glazy.org · Ceramic Materials Workshop (Matt & Rose Katz) · Digitalfire · arXiv (GlazyBench, 2026) · GitHub, KyaniteLabs/openglaze · Wikipedia (Bernard Leach, Shōji Hamada, Leach Pottery, Peter Voulkos, Warren MacKenzie, Simon Leach, Lisa Hammond, Florian Gadsby, Jingdezhen porcelain) · The Leach Pottery (leachpottery.com) · Craft Council UK · Nippon.com · Mingei Film Archive · Minnesota Museum of American Art · Revere Auctions · Clay College Stoke / Adopt a Potter · Korea Ceramic Foundation · CNN & THE VALUE (moon jar auctions) · Bailey Pottery · Sheffield Pottery · The Ceramic Shop · Clay King · Krueger Pottery Supply · Dick Blick · Shimpco Ceramics · Amaco/Brent · Speedball · Skutt · L&L Kilns · Laguna/Pacifica · Venco

(Australia) · Rohde (Germany) · Mudtools · DiamondCore Tools · Tolbert Ceramics · Gardner Ceramics · Kilnbuilders · JL Pottery · Cherrico Pottery · Etsy (kick-wheel listings) · Kiln Frog · Hot Kilns · Soul Ceramics · Grand View Research / Business Research Insights / Research and Markets (market sizing) · Axios · Great Pottery Throw Down press coverage · BusinessDojo · BookClay · The Potters' Studio · EnviroKlenz · The Ceramic School · Old Forge Creations · Sell Pots · Emerson Creek Pottery · Global Reach Ceramic · World Fine Crafts · Mud Rock Ceramics · Thow Kwang Pottery Jungle · Goodman Ceramic Studio · Am I Addicted Korean Pottery Studio · Sam Mui Kuang Pottery · Southeast Asian Ceramic Society (seaceramic.org.sg) · Kaizenaire · Jumppy.com.sg · RADII · Sixth Tone · Taylor & Francis Online (Journal of Modern Craft) · RIBA (Taoxichuan) · WWD · Go China Freely · China Daily · Xinhua · International Academy of Ceramics (aic-iac.org) · Ceramics Now.